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Virginia House of Delegates Floor Session, Special Session 1, Thursday, April 23, 2026

Date	Thursday, April 23, 2026
Place	Virginia House of Delegates, House Chamber, State Capitol, Richmond
Length	1h 16m (video)

- Official floor video (House of Delegates archive, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JwPiQEr6wqk
- LIS House minutes: https://lis.virginia.gov/session-details/20261/minutes-list/H

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-16. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:01:38] House will come to order. Members, please take your seats. Sergeant-at-Arms. The House is now in session. All persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor, please retire to the gallery. The members will rise and be led in prayer by Pastor Veronica Thomas, First United Presbyterian Church, Norfolk. Remain standing for the Pledge of Allegiance to the flag of the United States of America, which is led by the delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Almighty God, we come this day to pray for our governor,

[00:02:15] our senators and delegates, their families and staff. We pray that they be given guidance, direction, instruction, and counsel concerning the problems and affairs of those who trust them to make decisions concerning their needs and values.

[00:02:36] We pray that our citizens have wisdom and discernment as they consider candidates for office. We pray that all unfair, wicked, and crooked leaders be exposed and ridded out from their position of authority and raise up in their place people of integrity, truth, and honesty.

[00:03:03] We are thankful that our prayers are better as much in victory and the word will not go out void. It will accomplish what it was sent to do, which is to bring the word to pass. in their lives in our state with praise and thanksgiving amen and we all say the universal praise hallelujah hallelujah hallelujah hallelujah hallelujah hallelujah calm down lady lady lady

[00:03:38] hallelujah hallelujah hallelujah all right the members will answer the roll call by indicating

[00:04:27] their presence on the electronic voting board. Clerk will close the row. Mr. Speaker, form is present. The clerk will report a communication from the governor. Mr. Speaker, remind the body as we prepare for this 2026 Special Session 1, pursuant to House Joint Resolution 317, agreed to by two-thirds of the majority of both bodies on March 14th, pursuant to Article 4,

[00:05:05] Section 6, which directs that the governor shall convene a special session upon such application by those elected to each House. Accordingly, the Governor of the Commonwealth, Abigail Spanberger, issued a proclamation calling for a special session to meet in the respective chambers in Richmond commencing the 23rd day of April for the purpose of completing the 2026-2028 biannual budget and appointment subject to confirmation by the General Assembly.

[00:05:34] As the House is operating on the 2026-2027 rules of the House of Delegates during Special Session 1, The delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring, will please advise the Senate that the House of Delegates is organized and ready to proceed with business.

[00:05:54] House will be at ease.

[00:09:20] The House will come to order.

[00:12:46] Motions and resolutions under Rule 39 pursuant to the provisions of Rule 40 are now in order. Clerk shall announce the first morning hour order of business, including any clerk's announcements and communications. Mr. Speaker, members of the House, no announcements for communications. Therefore, this first portion of the morning hour pursuant to House Rule 40, the Speaker will request you to use your request to speak button for the agenda items listed for reference up on the voting board.

[00:13:07] Delegate from Norfolk. Delegate Glass. Gratitude, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an announcement, an introduction, an introduction. Hallelujah to Delegate Evans. Well, she did what I'm, what I believe she is. Today is my honor to introduce Pastor Veronica Thomas, lovingly known as Pastor V. Now I'm going to be transparent. I don't claim to have a church home in the traditional sense my faith lives deeply and personally and it is hard earned and because of that because of my own journey because of my own church hurt I do not take lightly being in the presence of someone

[00:13:47] who truly understands what it means to serve God's people with joy with love and with intention Pastor V is that kind of servant both spiritual and public service leadership is not simply a position it is about responsibility it is about serving with purpose leading with integrity and remaining accountable to the people placed in our care and that is what makes meaningful service that is what makes leadership worthy pastor v is a beautiful reflection of that truth she's a proud daughter of monroe louisiana a gambling gambling state woman a loving wife

[00:14:25] a mother of four the fast and the pastor of first united presbyterian church in norfolk Virginia but more than her titles what makes her remarkable is her spirit which you all hope felt today she carries herself in a way that lets you know her heart before she even announces it she reminds us in work and in word that we are here to serve and that when God brings peoples to us it is because we are meant to be a blessing and I'll say this to Pastor Veronica because this is sat with me since I heard her said it. She said, we are here to serve. That is what we do. We thank

[00:15:04] God that he brings to us those who need to be served. That is what God calls us to do. We want to be a blessing. Gratitude for that, Pastor Veronica. And that, and with that powerful reminder is from Pastor Veronica, is that service must be substance. That joy is the mission, that love is part of the mission and that accountability is not separate from service. It is one of the clear signs that service is real. Pastor V reminds us in this season and in this space, truth matters.

[00:15:37] She calls every leader in, in every institution to remember the assignment. And as Galatians 6, 9 tells us, let us not grow weary in doing good for in due season, we shall reap if we faint not.

[00:15:55] Pastor V does not faint. Her joy, her love does not faint. She knows, she shows us what it means to carry gentleness and strength at every time. Please join me in giving a warm house welcome to Pastor Veronica Thomas, a.k.a. Pastor V, and her amazing daughter, Lizette, joining us in the

[00:16:15] house today. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. You don't need a welcome. You just bully your way in, huh? The delegate from Fredericksburg, Delegate Cole. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise today for a motion. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I move that we take up H.R. 2002 on page three of today's calendar out of order and speaking to that motion.

[00:16:53] Clerk will pour a resolution. House resolution 2002 commending the University of Mary Washington men's basketball team. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Joining us in the gallery today is the University of Mary Washington's men's basketball team, our 2026 NCAA Division III national champions.

[00:17:12] They made history when they secured the first national title for a men's team in the university's history, finishing an extraordinary 30-3 season.

[00:17:29] They did it in dramatic fashion, Mr. Speaker, winning the national championship on a last-second shot that was seen across the country and celebrated as one of the top plays in sports. But beyond that moment, Mr. Speaker, this team represents sustained excellence. they rose to the top of division three basketball brought national attention to the commonwealth and made Fredericksburg and the commonwealth proud a few minutes ago they met with the governor and the governor said when did you know you were going to win and they said with a rousing shocking

[00:17:59] response in august when the season started mr speaker they are with us today with their coaches the university president and leadership and after we hopefully approve the resolution i hope it would be the will of the body, on behalf of myself and Delegate Scott from Spotsylvania, Delegate Cole from Spotsylvania, Delegate Franklin of Woodbridge, Delegate Carol of Stafford, that we give them a warm House welcome.

[00:18:28] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. He said afterwards. He said afterwards. He was clear. They don't follow instructions, Joshua. The delegate from Fredericksburg, Delegate Josh Cole, moves that the House adopt House Resolution 2002, commending the University of Mary Washington men's basketball team.

[00:18:45] All those in favor of the motion shall say aye. Aye. All those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. Congratulations. The delegate from Chesterfield, Delegate Gartner.

[00:19:18] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for two motions. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I move that we take out of order House Resolution 2037 on page two. Clerk, what are the resolution?

[00:19:34] House Resolution 2037, celebrating the life of Wilhelmina Gregory James. And I would ask that the family member of, which is one of our own, Wilhelmina Gregory James, please rise.

[00:19:51] Wilhelmina Gregory James, also known as Queen Wilhelmina by her closest friends, was born in Herpford, North Carolina. Later made Brooklyn, New York her home, the place where she and her husband of 67 years, Rudolph James, built their life, raised their children, and created a legacy rooted in love, creativity, and community.

[00:20:14] A retired narcotics correction officer of women and later teenage boys, she carried herself with quiet strength, dignity, and unwavering compassion and feistiness. After retirement, she and Rudy moved to Virginia with a few family members where she continued to be a cherished presence as they started a new life.

[00:20:38] She was known throughout the neighborhood in North Chesterfield as a trusted caregiver for children, lovingly watching newborns through junior high schoolers, offering families a sense of safety and stability that she could provide. Wilhelmina leaves behind a legacy of love, creativity, service, and family, a life lived with purpose, generosity, and grace.

[00:21:04] Mr. Speaker, my second motion is that when we adjourn today, we adjourn in the honor and memory of Wilhelmina Gregory James. The delegate from Chesterfield, Delegate Gardner, moves that the House adopt House Resolution 2037, and when the House adjourns today, it do so in the honor and memory of Wilhelmina Gregory James.

[00:21:28] All those in favor of the motion shall please rise. Motion is agreed to.

[00:21:45] The delegate from Alexandria, Delegate McPike. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a motion. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:22:00] I move that the House take up, out of order, House Resolution 2045 on page 2 of today's calendar. Clerk will report the resolution. House Resolution 2045, celebrating the life of Madison Warner. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I move adoption of the resolution and request to speak to the motion.

[00:22:17] The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I know that all of us in this chamber and across Virginia were heartbroken when we learned earlier this week that Madison Collis Warner, the daughter of Senator Mark Warner and his wife, Lisa Collis. had passed away at the age of 36.

[00:22:34] Madison was a young woman who was beloved by her friends and her family, a private person who lived much of her life in or near the public eye. Madison will be remembered by all who knew her as a bright and kind and thoughtful person, someone whose laughter was contagious and whose resolve was unshakable.

[00:22:52] We all knew of her brave and determined fight with juvenile diabetes, and her passing highlights once again the need to do more to understand this illness and to find a true cure. No words in this chamber can heal the pain felt by parents who have lost a beloved child, sisters who have lost a cherished sibling, or friends who have lost one of the most important people in their lives.

[00:23:16] But Senator Warner, Ms. Collis, Jillian and Liza, you and Madison have all lived your lives in ways that have served the Commonwealth and this nation, and we and all the Virginians we represent join you in mourning this tragic loss.

[00:23:32] Madison will be remembered for her kindness, her goodness, her humor, and her bravery. She will continue to inspire others facing difficult health challenges. She will continue to be loved not only by her family and her friends, but as a daughter of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:23:50] And so, Mr. Speaker, I again move adoption of the resolution and further move that when the House adjourned today, it adjourned in honor and in memory of Madison Collis Warner. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Mike Pike, moves that the House adopt House Resolution 2045, celebrating the life of Madison College Warner, and that when the House adjourns today, it do so in the honor and memory of Madison College Warner.

[00:24:13] All those in favor of the motion shall rise. The motion is agreed to. The Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Watts. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:24:35] I rise for a motion. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I move that when the House adjourns today, it adjourned in the honor and memory of former Delegate Marion Van Landingham and asked to speak to that motion. The Delegate has the floor.

[00:24:52] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate Van Landingham and I came in together. Her name was always above mine, squeezed into the voting, and I always thought she should have part of my space because it was only Watts.

[00:25:08] When I say that I came in and there had only been 21 women before us, it is because Marion and I came in together, three Democrats, one Republican woman came in together. And suddenly there was a new breath within the General Assembly.

[00:25:26] Why did we come in at that time? Suddenly four of us after so long, so few? Well, it was the last year under the original congressional resolution to pass the ERA. Well, here I still am. But enough of that and enough of Marion's and my delegation to accomplish that.

[00:25:46] What I will say is that Marion accomplished very much within her lifetime, which was long and robust. For more than two decades, she represented parts of Alexandria, Arlington, and Fairfax in the House of Delegates.

[00:26:02] She became the first woman to chair the Committee on Privileges and Elections. And she was a tireless advocate for public education, child care, mental health services, and the needs of the elderly and unhoused, and carried that out with great effectiveness as a member of house appropriations.

[00:26:23] Had the unfortunate information come through that she was facing cancer in 2005, that was diagnosed at that time as being fatal, and she left the house.

[00:26:40] She would have been, I'm sure, the second woman to have chaired house appropriations with all of her dedication to that committee. But instead, she left, and one of her decisions in leaving was to leave to her beloved torpedo factory all of the proceeds of her artwork, which were then sold.

[00:27:10] And I wanted to mention that because there's a legacy within this body. And when you're waiting for whatever reason, you're up on the 12th floor in the appropriations room, you will see on facing the doors as you would be going in or exiting a magnificent painting that she did that the house bought on her and her honor at that sale of her work.

[00:27:38] It is an excellent work, and it allows you to understand just what this woman was as an individual. As we all have our farewells when someone leaves the house, this is the woman. Now, these

words were written by current delegate McPike, and he talks very matter-of-factly on how in 1970 she led the effort to convert a derelict weapons manufacturing site, the torpedo factory, and the Alexandria waterfront into a first-of-its-kind public art facility,

[00:28:15] one that has served as a model for similar facilities across the nation, providing artists with space they needed to practice their craft or inspired by visitors coming and also being able to purchase. Now, those are the official words. What I know of Marian spirit was that she was there in this old torpedo factory cleaning it up. And I mean, forgive all of the pigeon poop that was on all the rafters and on the floors. And she made it

[00:28:51] happen by not only in belief of what it could offer to artists and to the public and their appreciation of art, but also just what it took to make it happen. As someone who took every advantage to give back to her community, Delegate Van Landingham sought to inspire others to do the same, and in 1980, she was the first executive director of what is today Volunteer Alexandria, an organization which provides essential support to local events, charities,

[00:29:27] and residents. Delegate Van Landingham's commitment to her community earned her many recognitions throughout her life, including being named Living Legend of Alexandria, and the 1974 Washingtonian of the Year for her work on the Torpedo Factory. Mr. Speaker, former Delegate Marion Van Landingham's life was one of purpose and service, and this body and this Commonwealth are greater because of her efforts for that reason i move that when the house adjourned today

[00:30:04] it do so in honor and memory of former marion former delegate marion van landingham do you want to as well move house resolution mr speaker i would be pleased to do so i would move that we adopt house resolution uh 2011. the delegate for fairfax wats wats moves that the house adopt house resolution 2011 celebrating the life of the Honorable Mary Van Lendingham and when the house adjourns today it do so in the honor in memory of the Honorable

[00:30:41] Marian Van Lendingham. All those in favor of adoption of the motion shall please

[00:30:45] rise. The motion is agreed to. The House will be at ease. The House will come to

[01:02:50] order. Delegate from Alexander. Delegate Heron. Thank you Mr. Speaker. I rise for a motion. Delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker I move that we adopt House resolution number 2069 and speaking to that motion. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[01:03:07] Members of the House, this is a single house resolution, provides for us to have time to consider the budget bill. We do also allow for single house commending and memorial resolutions, rules affecting procedure of this chamber, and election of judges.

[01:03:24] There's still in this resolution that we'll have 48 hours' notice before we're called back by the Speaker, as well as notice before consideration of the budget bill. I yield for any questions. Clerk will report a resolution. Mr. Speaker.

[01:03:39] Mr. Speaker. The delegate from County, Delegate Kilgall. Mr. Speaker, I would encourage a yes on the resolution. Mr. Speaker, as the Majority Leader said, House Resolution 2069, limiting legislation to be considered by the 2026 Special Session 1 of the General Assembly in establishing a schedule for the content of a business coming before such special session is now before the body.

[01:04:02] Delegate from Alexander, Delegate Henry. Mr. Speaker, move the adoption of the resolution. Shall the resolution be agreed to? Clerk will close the roll.

[01:04:20] Ayes 93, nos 0. The resolution, ayes 93, nos 0, the resolution is agreed to. Pursuant to House Rule 30, the journal shall reflect that the following members are aware of the present personal business that are granted leave for today's session.

[01:04:36] Delegates Converse Fowler, Garrett, Oates, Widow, and Williams. Delegate from Fauquier County, Delegate McAuliffe. Thank you, Mr. Speaker, I rest for a motion. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House take up out of order H.R. 2032 and move adoption of that resolution on page number two of today's calendar.

[01:04:59] Delegate from, you'd like to speak to the motion? No, sir. Okay. We would have got there, but okay. Delegate from Farquhar County moves that we adopt House Resolution 2032. All those in favor say aye. Aye. All those opposed, no.

[01:05:16] Is that a memorial resolution? It's a memorial, sir. Oh, the delegate from Farquhar County moves that the House adopt House Resolution 2032. Celebrating the life of Gail Wilson, all those in favor of the motion shall please rise.

[01:05:41] The resolution is agreed to. Clerk will put a resolution. Mr. Speaker, House Resolution No. 2052, Salaries and Contingent and Incidental Expenses, patroned by a delegator and resolved by the House of Delegates, the Comptroller is directed to issue his warrants on the Treasurer payable from the contingent fund of the House to accomplish the work of the House of Delegates during the 2026 Special Session of the General Assembly.

[01:06:09] necessary payments to cover salaries of temporary employees as well as contingent incidental expenses will be certified by the clerk or his designee. Resolved finally that the members of the House of Delegates shall receive session per diem for any day they attend a scheduled floor session at which an attendance roll call is taken. Sessions per diem shall not be allowed for legislative assistance. Sessions per diem shall not be allowed for members of the House of Delegates during a recess of the special session. However, members may receive compensation while the House of Delegates is in recess as provided in section 30-19.12 of the Code of Virginia as follows.

[01:06:38] as members of any standing committee, members of any committee of conference, or members of any legislative committee, commission, or council established by the General Assembly. H.R. 2052 is now -- Delegate from Prince William, delegatorian. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[01:06:53] Mr. Speaker, the clerk has articulated H.R. 2052. Mr. Speaker, I move adoption of the resolution. Shall the resolution be agreed to? Clerk will close the row.

[01:07:14] Ayes 90, nos 0. Ayes 90, nos 0. The resolution is agreed to. - Clerk will announce the next order, Bill. - Second portion of the morning hour, I'm not aware of any requests, sir. - Clerk shall announce the next order, Bill. - Third portion of the morning hour, reserved for member requests for legislation. Goodbye for the day, I'm not aware of any of those as well.

[01:07:30] - The clerk shall announce the next order, Bill. - Fourth and final portion of the morning hour in special session one is reserved for points of personal privilege, kindly use your request to speak button if you're so inclined to speak. - The delegate from Newport News, Delegate Simons.

[01:07:46] - Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. - The delegate has the floor. - Mr. Speaker, today I would like to congratulate and thank NASA Langley Research Center for its extraordinary contributions to the Artemis II space mission.

[01:08:03] The Artemis program is one of the most ambitious space exploration efforts of our time. Returning humans to the moon for the first time in over 50 years and laying the foundation for future space exploration. And right here in Virginia, NASA Langley is helping make that possible.

[01:08:23] I wanted to share with my colleagues for a moment what it was like to watch the Artemis II launch with scientists and engineers at NASA in their cafeteria in Hampton. There was a loud celebratory atmosphere, but it really got my attention when everyone would suddenly go silent.

[01:08:43] There were moments of tension, of potential danger, when things could have gone wrong. The first was at about six seconds to go in the countdown, when the engines fired with a massive roar. Once we had liftoff, there was a collective sigh of relief.

[01:09:00] Then about one minute after the launch, people began talking about when Artemis would reach Max Q. Max Q is when the pressure forces on the capsule are the strongest. Max Q passed, and the Artemis mission continued. At another moment, about eight minutes in, it seemed like everyone in the building was holding their breath as we waited for the Orion capsule to separate from the core stage rocket, which is as long as six school buses stacked bumper to bumper.

[01:09:31] Once again, Artemis II made it through. Being there, I could feel how personal this mission was to the NASA community. Everything NASA researchers do is about the safety of these astronauts. Every minute of their journey around the moon is a test of their work, their calculations, their experiments, their engineering.

[01:09:53] The Artemis II mission was a culmination of years of work at NASA that paid off when astronauts Reed Wiseman, Victor Glover, Christina Koch, and Jeremy Hansen captured images of the far side of the moon that no one had ever seen before and traveled further from Earth than any human has ever gone.

[01:10:17] before. Records were broken. Victor Glover made history as the first black person to ever pilot a lunar mission, a milestone that reflects both the progress we've made and the future that we are building. Achievements like this bring us together as a nation at a time when we really need it most. NASA Langley contributed to the mission by building components of the next generation spacesuits, designing descent and earth entry systems, and using optical laser-based measurements to inform the underlying physics of space flight.

[01:10:53] They also worked alongside commercial industry leaders on human landing systems and provided expertise in aerodynamics, navigation, systems engineering, and they even are researching how powerful lunar landings interact with the moon's surface to reduce the risk for future missions. This cutting-edge work is advancing science, strengthening our economy, and inspiring the next generation of explorers. We are proud that this groundbreaking work is happening right here in Virginia, and that the Commonwealth continues to play a leading role in the next

[01:11:31] chapter of human space exploration. So today, Mr. Speaker, I ask that the body join me in congratulating the men and women of NASA Langley Research Center. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Clerk will

call the calendar. Calendar for today, Thursday, April 23rd for this 2026 special session one. Page one, first category, Memorial Resolutions laid on the Speaker's table. Memorial Resolutions

[01:12:10] will be adopted in blockers spread across pages one and two with the exception of House Resolution 211, 2032, 2037, and 2045. They've been adopted. The rest of them remain in the block, which are now before you. Does any member desire to remove a resolution from the block?

[01:12:27] Hearing none, all those in favor of adopting in block, the memorial resolutions laid on the Speaker's table as listed on pages 1 and 2 of the calendar will please rise. The resolutions are agreed to.

[01:12:45] Continuing, page 2 of the printed calendar, next category, commending resolutions laid on the Speaker's table. The commending resolution to be adopted in block are spread across pages 2 through 6 With the exception of HR 2002, which has been already adopted, and then an act of expediency and help, there are four additional resolutions that are not in the printed calendar but are available online.

[01:13:09] They will be in the block as well. So those four are House Resolution 2053, House Resolution 2054, House Resolution 255, and House Resolution 260. All of those are in the block, save for House Resolution 2002, which has already been adopted.

[01:13:27] Does any member desire to remove a resolution from the block? Do you need this? Hearing none, all those in favor have adopted in block. The committee resolution is laid on Speaker's table as listed on pages 2 through 6, and those added by the clerk, as announced, will say aye. Those opposed, no. The resolutions are agreed to.

[01:13:45] That completes today's calendar. Per House Rule 51, the House is returned to the morning hour. Does the clerk have any additional announcements or communications? Just a reminder, announcement, during the end, once we adjourn here momentarily, you can – the House IT staff, information technology staff will remain in the chamber for anyone who's interested and wants to receive their new devices, turn in their old ones because we're updating things accordingly.

[01:14:10] Also looking ahead, as soon as we adjourn, the Democratic caucus will be meeting in House room one immediately upon the recess subject to the procedural resolution that we're operating under. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House stand in recess pursuant to the provisions of House Resolution 2069.

[01:14:32] The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves that the House stand in recess pursuant to the provisions of House Resolution 2069. As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The House stands in recess pursuant to the provisions of House Resolution Number 2069.

